

Hypericum perforatum (Hypericaceae)

St. John's Wort

St. John's wort flowers at the summer solstice. In medieval Europe it was considered to have the power to protect against ill health and evil influences. Medicinally it was thought to heal wounds and "all down-heartedness." In the 19th century the herb fell into disuse, but recent research has brought it back into prominence as a key herb for nervous exhaustion and depression. It is now one of the most used herbal medicines in the world.



St. John's wort was a folk remedy for insanity in the Middle Ages.

Habitat & Cultivation

St. John's wort thrives in temperate regions worldwide. It prefers a sunny site and well-drained, chalky soil. It can be grown from seed or by root division in autumn. The flowering tops are harvested in summer.

Related Species

A number of other *Hypericum* species have a roughly similar medicinal action.

Key Constituents

- Phloroglucinols (hyperforin)
- Polycyclic diones (hypericin)
- Flavonoids

Key Actions

- Antidepressant
- Anxiolytic
- Antiviral
- Wound healer
- Anti-inflammatory

Research

■ **Depression** Clinical research since the 1970s has established St. John's wort as an effective treatment for mild to moderate depression.

A review in 2009 also concluded that the herb was helpful in treating severe depression. Research shows that St. John's wort works on neurotransmitter levels (e.g. serotonin) in several different ways.

■ **Viral infection** St. John's wort extracts (particularly hypericin, the red pigment found in the petals and leaves) have strong antiviral activity, notably against influenza, herpes, and hepatitis B and C.

■ **Safety** St. John's wort rarely causes side effects itself, but it does interact with certain conventional medicines, mostly increasing the rate at which they are broken down by the liver. This changes the amount of the drug present in the bloodstream, significantly reducing its effectiveness. In rare situations, this can be life threatening.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Nerve tonic** The herb acts as a restorative and neuroprotective, helping to reverse long-term nervous exhaustion and lowered mood. It can prove useful in seasonal affective disorder and chronic anxiety, and improves sleep quality.

■ **Menopause** The herb is considered a specific for the lowered mood that can accompany menopause, often combined with black cohosh (*Cimicifuga racemosa*, p. 79) in such cases.

■ **Tissue healing** The red infused oil has potent wound-healing properties and historically has been used to heal knife and stab wounds. Nowadays, St. John's wort oil is more

**St. John's wort**

An erect perennial growing to 32 in (80 cm), with bright yellow flowers in a flat-topped cluster.

Parts Used

Flowering tops are picked when the flowers have opened.

Bright yellow petals have oil glands containing hypericin

**Key Preparations & Their Uses**

⚠ **Cautions** Can cause sensitivity to sunlight. Due to possible interactions, seek professional advice if taking a prescribed medicine, including blood thinners. Restricted in some countries. Do not combine with other antidepressants.



Infused oil Make by steeping the herb in oil for 6 weeks (see p. 294). Dab onto minor wounds and burns.



Cream (to make, p. 296). For cramps or neuralgia, rub onto the affected part.



Tincture (to make, p. 292). For depression, take ½ tsp with water 3 times a day.



Infusion (to make, p. 291). Drink ½ cup (100 ml) daily as a digestive tonic.

commonly used to promote healing after surgery and minor burns. The oil can be particularly helpful in relieving neuralgia—shingles, sciatica, and toothache being common applications.

Self-help Uses

■ **Anxiety, depression & tension**, p. 308.

- **Back pain**, p. 313.
- **Bites & stings**, p. 303.
- **Cold sores, chicken pox, & shingles**, p. 304.
- **Depression & decreased vitality due to menopause**, p. 316.
- **Neuralgia**, p. 308.
- **Stiff & aching joints**, p. 313.
- **Tired & aching muscles**, p. 312.